

everything there was to know about other athletes and their performances. Apart from that, one of Neeraj's greatest strengths is his creativity. He is always curious about various exercises — why something worked and why others didn't. He was always looking for ways to improve," he says.

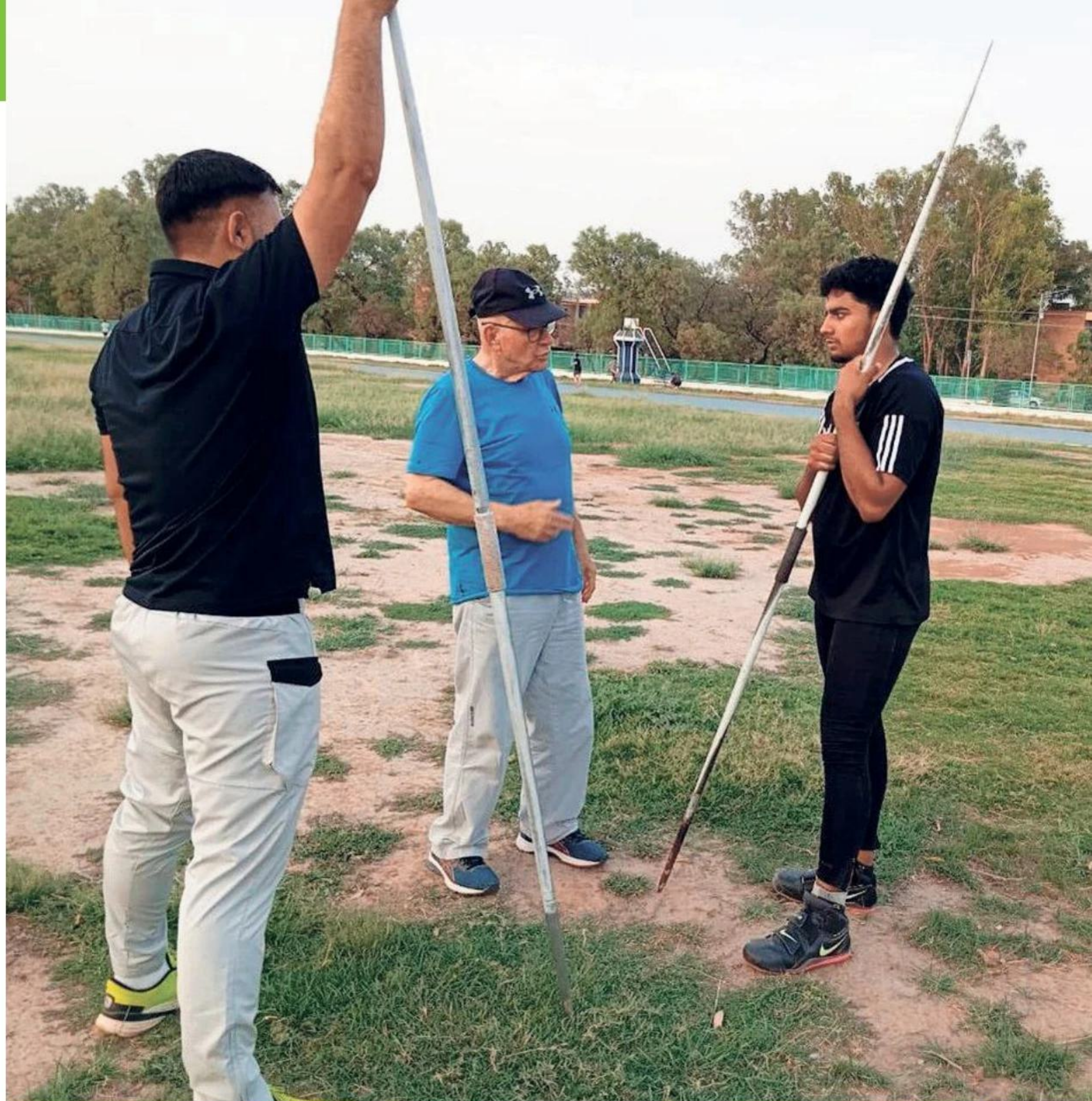
But there was something even more important that Neeraj had, feels Klaus. It was his sense of honesty. "Those are Neeraj's best qualities. His brain and his honesty," says Klaus. According to him, that is in short supply in Indian athletics. Athletes took advantage of each other, and intrigue was commonplace.

"I don't think the system in India is very honest. The middle administration wants to feel important regardless of what is needed. Very early in my time in India, I came across an incident when a senior athlete took money from a younger thrower. The junior didn't even realise he was being taken advantage of, and I had to go and recover his money," says Klaus.

Uwe Hohn, Neeraj's former coach, was subject to this too. "Before the Tokyo Olympics, it was clear that there were officials trying to get rid of him or at least not renew his contract. They had a couple of senior athletes give evidence that Uwe was coaching an athlete from Australia instead of paying attention to them. I was shocked at that. I said nothing like this had happened. It wasn't that Uwe was a bad coach. He had taken Neeraj to the Commonwealth and Asian Games gold. And when I asked these athletes why they had done this, they just said it was what they had to do," says Klaus.

He says he considered resigning alongside Uwe "as a matter of principle" before ultimately deciding to stay on with Neeraj.

There was none of this constant intrigue around Neeraj though. Klaus still isn't entirely clear why. "I think some of it probably has to do with his upbringing. Most of family members are farmers and is a very decent group of people. But there was a clear honesty to Neeraj which



was not common when I worked here. The other seniors would treat juniors like servants. They would have them carry their equipment after their sessions. I've never once seen Neeraj not carry his own javelins himself. There was never this sense of superiority — and this was after he became an Olympic champion," he says.

Some of Neeraj's honesty, Klaus feels, came from his motivation for getting into sport in the first place. "I think a lot of the problem comes when you get into the sport because you are thinking about the outcome. I remember a piece of news I saw before the Tokyo Olympics, where Shivpal (Singh) was meeting the UP Chief Minister and he said something like India would win three medals but was not sure about the colour.

Perhaps this happened to Johannes Vetter too. He was going into the Olympics as the huge favourite. I think he was thinking about breaking the world record there, but in the end, he picked up an injury. But I always felt it was very different for Neeraj. He was

Expert advice: Young javelin throwers like Himanshu (right) have the privilege of being mentored by Klaus. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

motivated by the process of throwing, never by the outcome. Because of that, it was never difficult to keep him focused," says Klaus.

His own role, he says, was fairly simple. "As a teacher, I only had to support him in training and keep him on the right path. I don't think there was any pressure on me to work with Neeraj. I think the pressure was more on him. As a coach, I didn't think I could do it anymore, so there was no point in panicking. My job was to stay quiet and not do anything stupid that would disturb him," says Klaus.

While Klaus was able to play this role to perfection, some instances were harder than others. "The one time I was really nervous — like I was back in school giving an examination again — was before the finals of the Tokyo Olympics," he says.

The Olympic gold, unexpected as